

NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA GURUKULAM

Centre for Civilisational Statecraft

CIVILISATIONAL STATECRAFT SERIES | WORKING PAPER VII

DHARMIC ORDERING OF THE COSMIC COMMONS

Statecraft, Legitimacy, and Equilibrium
in the New Space Age



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April 2026 | Navi Mumbai

Working Paper — Draft for Circulation

Version 2.0 | April 2026

Comments and feedback are welcome.



Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā

Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.

Executive Summary

Human expansion into outer space is accelerating, increasingly driven by large-scale commercial activity and private actors, but without a corresponding evolution in the principles needed to sustain order. Emerging strategic analyses underscore how control over orbital infrastructure and data flows can generate enduring advantage, yet remain limited in addressing how such power is to be normatively stabilised within an integrated Earth–space system.

The space domain is treated as a unified domain in which actions in orbit generate cascading consequences for terrestrial infrastructure and vice versa.

Existing frameworks in international relations explain aspects of this condition but remain insufficient to integrate power, institutions, and norms into a coherent and sustainable order.

This paper proposes *dharma*, understood not as moral prescription but as a principle of systemic equilibrium that aligns capability, conduct, and consequence, as an ordering framework for the cosmic commons. Drawing on the *Arthaśāstra*, it reframes the exercise of power as requiring disciplined calibration and argues that the legitimacy of coercive capacity depends on its alignment with *dharma* as a condition of long-term stability and effective statecraft.

It further argues that in high-visibility, low-enforcement domains such as outer space, order depends not only on action, but equally on perception and its role in shaping legitimacy, trust, and coordination. The *Nāṭyaśāstra* provides a conceptual lens for understanding how coherence between intention, expression, and reception shapes legitimacy and trust.

The paper’s central claim is that sustainable order in space requires both institutional design and the cultivation of dispositions that align action with consequence across time. In this view, embodied disciplines such as *nāṭya* function as civilisational infrastructures that support the internalisation of order.

As humanity enters a new space age, the challenge is not merely to govern expansion, but to order human activity within a shared domain in a manner that preserves long-term stability, intergenerational viability, and systemic coherence.

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I. Introduction: Expansion Without an Ordering Principle

In April 2026, the launch of Artemis II marked a symbolic and operational turning point in humanity's return to deep space. For the first time in more than five decades, human beings ventured beyond low Earth orbit, inaugurating what is widely described as a 'new space age.'¹ Yet this renewed expansion is unfolding in the absence of a commensurate evolution in governance frameworks, normative principles, or any coherent civilisational orientation.

The contemporary space domain is thus characterised not simply by competition or cooperation, but by a more fundamental condition: an acceleration-driven expansion of capability without an integrating ordering principle capable of regulating scale, consequence, and systemic equilibrium. Recent developments indicate that this expansion is increasingly led by private actors pursuing large-scale satellite deployments, spectrum acquisition, and integrated space-based services, intensifying both capability and systemic congestion.² Technological capability has advanced dramatically, and space is increasingly framed as a commercial frontier, with projections of a lunar economy reaching tens of billions of dollars in the coming decades.³ At the same time, the regulatory architecture governing this expansion remains rooted in mid-twentieth-century treaties designed for a far less crowded and less complex environment.⁴

This imbalance is evident in the proliferation of space activity. The year 2025 alone witnessed over 300 launches and the placement of more than 4,600 objects into orbit, contributing to a sharp increase in congestion and systemic risk.⁵ The resulting challenges, of orbital debris, traffic management, and the potential militarisation of space, are not merely technical problems, but manifestations of a deeper absence of ordering at the level of principle. This condition is further underscored by emerging operational data. Recent assessments indicate a dramatic rise in collision alerts and avoidance

¹ Shine Jacob, "Around the Moon in 10 Days," *Business Standard*, April 3, 2026.

² Amira McKee, "The Bezos vs. Musk Space Race Is Heating Up," *Wall Street Journal*, April 14, 2026.

³ *Ibid.*

⁴ Shrawani Shagun and Abhiram Nair, "Earth's Orbits Are Filling Up Because Governance Hasn't Kept Pace," *The Hindu*, April 1, 2026.

⁵ "Over 4,600 Objects Placed in Orbit in 2025 After 315 Space Launches: Report," *The Hindu*, April 9, 2026.

manoeuvres, suggesting that orbital activity is increasingly sustained through continuous corrective intervention rather than stable equilibrium.⁶

This condition must also be understood within an integrated Earth–space system.⁷ Activities in outer space are not insulated from terrestrial consequences; orbital disruption, debris cascades, or failure of space-based infrastructure may generate cascading effects on Earth, affecting communication, navigation, and critical civilian and strategic systems. At the same time, contemporary narratives that frame space as an eventual alternative to Earth risk introducing a conceptual misalignment. Expansion into space does not constitute an exit from terrestrial responsibility, but an extension of it across domains. The ordering of the cosmic commons must therefore proceed on the premise that Earth remains the primary locus of human obligation, and that space activity must be aligned with the long-term stability of both domains.

Terrestrial systems enable space activity through launch capability, governance frameworks, and economic investment, while space-based assets sustain critical functions on Earth, including communication, navigation, and environmental monitoring. Disruptions in either domain are therefore not contained but propagated across the system, reinforcing the need to conceptualise order as spanning, rather than separating, Earth and space.

This condition is further intensified by the growing centrality of large private actors whose activities are oriented toward rapid scale. Proposals for extensive satellite constellations, integrated communication infrastructures, and orbital data systems indicate a trajectory of expansion that is both technologically transformative and systemically consequential, yet not anchored in a shared principle of equilibrium.

⁶ Pioneer News Service, “ISRO Report: 1.5 Lakh Space Collision Alerts Recorded in 2025,” *The Pioneer* (New Delhi), April 17, 2026.

⁷ National Aeronautics and Space Administration, *Space Sustainability Strategy*, 2023; Brian Weeden and Victoria Samson, *Global Counterspace Capabilities: An Open Source Assessment* (Washington, DC: Secure World Foundation, 2023).

Figure 1. Integrated Earth–space system:

Bidirectional flows of infrastructure, data, and consequence linking terrestrial and orbital domains into a single interdependent system.



Outer space is thus emerging as a layered commons, simultaneously strategic, commercial, informational, and infrastructural, amplifying both its value and its vulnerability to disorder.

Existing approaches in international relations offer partial insights into this condition. Realism explains the persistence of competition among major powers; liberal institutionalism highlights the role of treaties and regimes; and constructivism draws attention to norms and narratives. Yet none of these frameworks, in isolation or combination, fully addresses the question of how a stable and legitimate order may be constituted in a domain that is simultaneously strategic, economic, environmental, and meaning-laden.

This paper argues that addressing this gap requires the articulation of a unifying conceptual framework. Drawing on the classical Indian tradition of statecraft, and integrating it with contemporary international relations theory, it proposes that outer space must be understood as a cosmic commons requiring not merely governance, but the ordering of human activity within an integrated Earth–space system. The central claim advanced here is that such ordering depends on the articulation of *dharma*, understood not as moral prescription, but as a principle of systemic equilibrium that aligns capability, conduct, and consequence within a coherent and self-correcting order. This framing shifts the question from how activity in space is to be managed, to how a coherent and sustainable order of action and consequence is to be constituted and sustained.

II. Limits of Existing International Relations Frameworks

The contemporary space domain exhibits many features of what Kenneth Waltz described as an anarchic international system: the absence of a central authority, the persistence of uncertainty, and the necessity of self-help.⁸ Competition among major powers, particularly the United States and China, reflects this structural condition, as states seek to secure strategic advantage in satellite infrastructure, navigation systems, and potential extraterrestrial resources.

⁸ Kenneth N. Waltz, *Theory of International Politics* (Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1979).

Yet realism alone provides an incomplete account. By treating space as an extension of terrestrial geopolitics, it underestimates the cooperative and normative dimensions that also shape behaviour. Liberal institutionalism addresses this gap by emphasising the role of regimes and agreements in facilitating cooperation under anarchy.⁹ The Outer Space Treaty and subsequent norms represent attempts to establish such a framework. However, these institutions remain limited by weak enforcement mechanisms and an inability to keep pace with technological change and the entry of private actors.

Constructivist approaches further expand the analysis by highlighting the role of norms, identities, and narratives. As Alexander Wendt argues, the character of anarchy is not fixed but constructed through interaction.¹⁰ In the space domain, narratives of exploration, scientific progress, and shared human endeavour play a significant role in shaping expectations and legitimising activity.

Despite their respective strengths, these frameworks remain analytically fragmented. Realism foregrounds power but neglects legitimacy; liberalism emphasises institutions but underestimates strategic asymmetries; constructivism illuminates meaning but lacks a stabilising principle of order. What is missing is a conceptual lens capable of integrating these dimensions into a coherent account of order. This gap becomes particularly visible when examined against existing legal frameworks governing outer space.

II.A. Implicit Parallels in Existing Space Law

While not articulated in these terms, elements of systemic equilibrium are implicit in foundational space law instruments. The Outer Space Treaty establishes principles that align with restraint, shared benefit, and responsibility. Article I affirms that outer space shall be used for the benefit and in the interests of all countries, suggesting an orientation toward balanced and inclusive utilisation. Article II prohibits national appropriation, introducing a structural restraint on unilateral accumulation. Article III situates space activity within the

⁹ Robert O. Keohane, *After Hegemony* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1984).

¹⁰ Alexander Wendt, "Anarchy Is What States Make of It," *International Organization* 46, no. 2 (1992): 391–425.

framework of international law, reinforcing the alignment between conduct and consequence.¹¹

Similarly, the Moon Agreement incorporates an explicit concern for intergenerational equity, recognising that the benefits of outer space must extend across time.¹² These provisions, taken together, reflect an implicit concern with balance, restraint, and sustainability, elements that may be interpreted through the lens of *dharma* as systemic equilibrium.

III. The Arthaśāstra and Strategic Order

The *Arthaśāstra* offers an integrated account of political order under conditions of anarchy. While often interpreted as a realist text, it provides a broader framework that combines power, prudence, and normative constraint. This integration distinguishes it from purely structural accounts by embedding strategy within a logic of sustainability.

Central to this conception is the concept of the *maṇḍala*, or circle of states, in which relationships are dynamic and situational rather than fixed.¹³ Allies, adversaries, and intermediaries are defined not by permanent identities but by shifting configurations of interest and capability. Contemporary formations such as BRICS, ASEAN, and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation illustrate similar patterns of fluid, interest-based alignment, in which cooperation and competition coexist across overlapping domains. This perspective is particularly relevant to the space domain, where states may simultaneously compete in strategic arenas while cooperating in scientific missions.

Equally important is the *Arthaśāstra*'s emphasis on calibrated action. The exercise of power (*daṇḍa*) is embedded within a broader repertoire that includes diplomacy, inducement, and negotiation.¹⁴ This multidimensional approach recognises that coercion alone is insufficient to sustain order.

¹¹ United Nations, *Treaty on Principles Governing the Activities of States in the Exploration and Use of Outer Space, including the Moon and Other Celestial Bodies* (Outer Space Treaty), January 27, 1967, 610 U.N.T.S. 205.

¹² United Nations, *Agreement Governing the Activities of States on the Moon and Other Celestial Bodies*, December 5, 1979, 1363 U.N.T.S. 3

¹³ Kautilya, *Arthaśāstra*, trans. R. Shamasastri (1915), Book VI.

¹⁴ Ibid., Book VII.

At the same time, the pursuit of *artha* (material power and prosperity) is not unconstrained. It operates within a broader conceptual horizon that includes *dharma*, which functions as a principle of order and legitimacy.¹⁵ While not elaborated as a standalone doctrine, *dharma* operates as an implicit constraint, introducing the idea that the unrestrained pursuit of power can be self-defeating, generating instability that undermines long-term interests.

Crucially, this framework does not legitimate coercive capacity in the abstract. The *Arthaśāstra* explicitly recognises that the misuse of *daṇḍa* is itself a source of disorder. Officials who exercise force disproportionately or arbitrarily are themselves subject to sanction, reinforcing that the authority to wield coercion is inseparable from accountability in its application. In this formulation, legitimacy arises not merely from the possession of coercive capability, but from its disciplined, proportionate, and corrigible use in the preservation of order. This integration of power and constraint provides a foundation for rethinking the space domain, not merely as a site of competition, but as a system requiring ordered interaction.

Emerging literature on space power, exemplified by recent extensions of Mackinder's 'heartland' thesis to the orbital domain, demonstrates how control over orbital infrastructure, launch capacity, and data flows can generate enduring strategic advantage.¹⁶ Yet such analyses remain primarily descriptive of power concentration, offering limited guidance on how this concentration is to be normatively stabilised. In Kautilyan terms, the mere aggregation of capability, absent restraint, risks a drift toward *matsyanyāya*, a condition in which asymmetries enable the strong to externalise risk without systemic accountability.¹⁷

¹⁵ Ibid., Book I.

¹⁶ V. Siddhartha, "Space as the Ultimate Heartland: Mackinder's Geopolitical Theory in the Age of Orbital Warfare," *Journal of Strategic Studies* (2026), <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/14777622.2026.2622265>

¹⁷ Kautilya, *Arthaśāstra*, Book I, Chapter 4.

It is here that *daṇḍa nīti* becomes analytically salient. It accepts the necessity of enforceable order, but insists that the exercise of coercive capacity must be proportionate, purposive, and oriented toward the preservation of the system.¹⁸

In this formulation, the legitimacy of force arises not from monopoly, but from its alignment with *dharma*: coercive capacity is justified only insofar as it preserves order, proportion, and systemic balance.

If outer space is indeed emerging as a new ‘heartland,’ the central question is not only who commands it, but under what normative conditions such command is rendered legitimate and sustainable over time.

IV. Dharma as an Ordering Principle in the Cosmic Commons

In this paper, *dharma* is not invoked as a theological or moral doctrine, but as an analytic principle of order. It refers to the maintenance of systemic equilibrium through the alignment of action with consequence.

The preceding analysis points to a central limitation in existing approaches: the absence of a unifying principle capable of aligning expansion with sustainability. This section advances *dharma* as such a principle, reframing order not as the product of rules alone, but as the alignment of action, consequence, and systemic stability.

Classical formulations capture this succinctly: *dhārayati iti dharmah* (that which sustains) and *dharmo rakṣati rakṣitaḥ* (*dharma* protects when protected). Read in systemic terms, these formulations emphasise that order is sustained through alignment and preserved through its continued observance.

1. From Governance to Ordering

Contemporary space policy is largely framed in terms of governance: the development of rules, norms, and institutions. Such a shift requires movement from reactive regulation to anticipatory governance, in which institutional frameworks actively shape trajectories of innovation in alignment with systemic

¹⁸ Ibid., Book I, Chapters 4–5; Book VII, Chapter 1.

stability. Governance that merely responds to disruption risks institutionalising instability rather than preventing it. It addresses discrete problems without resolving the underlying tension between expansion and constraint.

An ordering perspective shifts the focus from compliance to systemic coherence. It asks whether actions contribute to the long-term stability and legitimacy of the domain as a whole. This formulation does not displace governance. Institutional frameworks provide structure and enforcement, while *dharma* shapes the conditions under which such frameworks are perceived as legitimate and sustained in practice. In domains where enforcement is limited, this alignment becomes critical.

2. Integration of Power, Institutions, and Norms

Dharma enables the integration of the core insights of IR theory:

- It recognises power asymmetries (realism), while constraining their destabilising effects
- It affirms the role of institutions (liberalism), while grounding them in systemic purpose
- It incorporates norms and meanings (constructivism), while orienting them toward equilibrium

In this sense, *dharma* functions as a meta-principle, rendering these dimensions commensurable.

3. Restraint and Systemic Viability

In an interdependent domain such as outer space, actions generate cumulative effects.¹⁹ Debris creation, congestion, and escalation are not isolated outcomes but systemic processes.

A *dhārmic* framework interprets restraint not as loss of advantage, but as the disciplined calibration of action in view of consequence. It internalises

¹⁹ McKee, “Bezos vs. Musk Space Race.”

externalities by aligning short-term action with long-term consequences, ensuring that the costs of disruption are borne within the system rather than displaced across it. Activities that degrade the commons, even if strategically advantageous, are understood as failures of ordering. Contemporary space activity increasingly reflects an acceleration logic driven by scale, iteration, and competitive positioning, often without reference to systemic thresholds. In such a context, restraint must be understood not as limitation, but as the condition for maintaining the viability of the domain itself. This pattern is increasingly observable in empirical terms. Recent data indicate a sharp rise in orbital congestion, with over 150,000 collision alerts recorded in a single year and a growing reliance on frequent collision avoidance manoeuvres to maintain operational safety. Such patterns suggest that the space domain is already operating under conditions of continuous corrective intervention. While these adjustments mitigate immediate risk, they reflect a reactive mode of stability rather than a condition of equilibrium. A *dhārmic* framework shifts the emphasis from post hoc correction to anticipatory restraint, recognising that the long-term viability of the domain depends not on the capacity to manage disruption, but on the discipline to limit its generation.²⁰

This aligns with emerging principles of intergenerational responsibility in space law, where present actions constrain future possibilities.²¹ In a domain where the consequences of action may persist over decades or longer, *dhārmic* ordering requires the incorporation of intergenerational responsibility. Orbital congestion, debris accumulation, and environmental degradation are not readily reversible within meaningful operational timeframes. Actions undertaken in the present may therefore constrain the range of viable choices available to future actors. This introduces a temporal dimension to ordering, in which coherence must be sustained not only across structures, but across time. Restraint, in this sense, is not only a strategic choice but a civilisational obligation, ensuring that the viability of the domain is preserved across generations.

²⁰ Pioneer News Service, “ISRO Report: 1.5 Lakh Space Collision Alerts.”

²¹ Ram S. Jakhu and Steven Freeland, “The Relationship between Space Law and Sustainability,” *Space Policy* 29, no. 1 (2013): 1–7.

4. Legitimacy and the Experiential Dimension of Order

In domains like outer space, where actions are highly visible, rules are difficult to enforce, and meaning is highly charged, collective perception does not merely reflect order; it helps constitute it. Legitimacy shapes behaviour by influencing trust, cooperation, and alignment among actors.

Classical Indian thought recognises that order must be both enacted and experienced. Traditions such as the *Nāṭyaśāstra* provide a vocabulary for understanding how structured action generates shared perception. Its central insight is that coherence between action, representation, and reception is essential to stability. This highlights a dimension often overlooked in international relations theory.

Accordingly, *dhārmic* ordering requires not only the calibration of action, but its alignment with perception. Inconsistencies between declared intent and observable behaviour undermine legitimacy and erode the conditions for cooperation. In an environment shaped by high visibility and continuous signalling, actions are interpreted through evolving narratives of intent, capability, and reliability, reinforcing the role of perception in constituting order.

This experiential dimension is not merely interpretive; it is constitutive. In domains such as outer space, where external enforcement is limited, the stability of order depends on the internalisation of proportion and restraint by actors. This alignment may also be understood in temporal terms. Classical Indian aesthetic practice recognises calibrated expression across varying tempos: *vilambita* (deliberate), *madhyama* (measured), and *druta* (accelerated). Transposed to domains of action, coherence is not only structural but rhythmic: the capacity to deliberate where necessary, sustain steady execution, and respond rapidly under conditions of disruption. The legitimacy of action is thus shaped not only by its content, but by its timing and proportion within a dynamic field of consequences. Misalignment in temporal calibration, whether premature acceleration or delayed response, can be as destabilising as disproportion in action itself.

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* offers disciplined modes through which such alignment may be cultivated. By structuring the relationship between intention, expression, and reception, it develops a sensitivity to coherence and consequence that extends beyond performance into domains of action. The ordering of the cosmic commons, therefore, cannot rely on institutional design alone; it must also be supported by practices that shape how order is perceived, enacted, and sustained.

Such practices perform a broader civilisational function: they cultivate dispositions of restraint, proportion, and coherence that carry into domains of decision-making. In this sense, embodied disciplines operate as formative infrastructures of order, shaping how actors perceive consequence and regulate conduct even in the absence of external enforcement. Where enforcement is limited, the sustainability of order depends precisely on such internalised regulation.

In the absence of a centralised authority, the operationalisation of such ordering depends on distributed mechanisms. These include the internalisation of norms, reputational consequences in a high-visibility environment, and the role of perception in shaping cooperation. Order, in such contexts, is sustained not solely through enforcement, but through alignment between action, expectation, and consequence.

The appendix develops this experiential dimension in greater detail, outlining how such alignment may be cultivated through disciplined practice

5. Dharma as Systemic Equilibrium

The space domain is not infinitely absorptive. Orbital slots, radio spectrum, and environmental stability constitute finite and interdependent resources. Expansion in any one dimension generates cascading constraints across the system, making unregulated accumulation a source of systemic fragility rather than strength.

Taken together, *dharma* may be understood as a principle of robust, self-correcting equilibrium. Such equilibrium does not imply static balance, but the

capacity of the system to absorb disturbance, adapt to changing conditions, and restore coherence after disruption. Current patterns of congestion indicate that the system is approaching a threshold at which self-correction alone may be insufficient to sustain stability.²² In an environment characterised by rapid technological change and increasing density of activity, the resilience of the system becomes as important as its initial ordering. It does not eliminate competition, but situates it within a framework that preserves the viability of the whole.

In the cosmic commons, this entails:

- Balancing expansion with sustainability
- Aligning strategic behaviour with long-term stability
- Integrating capability with legitimacy

Order, in this sense, is not static but continuously produced through the calibration of competing imperatives.

This relationship may be visualised as a triadic structure in which capability, conduct, and consequence are held in dynamic proportion, with *dharma* emerging as the condition of equilibrium generated through their alignment (see Figure 2 on the following page).

²² Pioneer News Service, “ISRO Report: 1.5 Lakh Space Collision Alerts.”

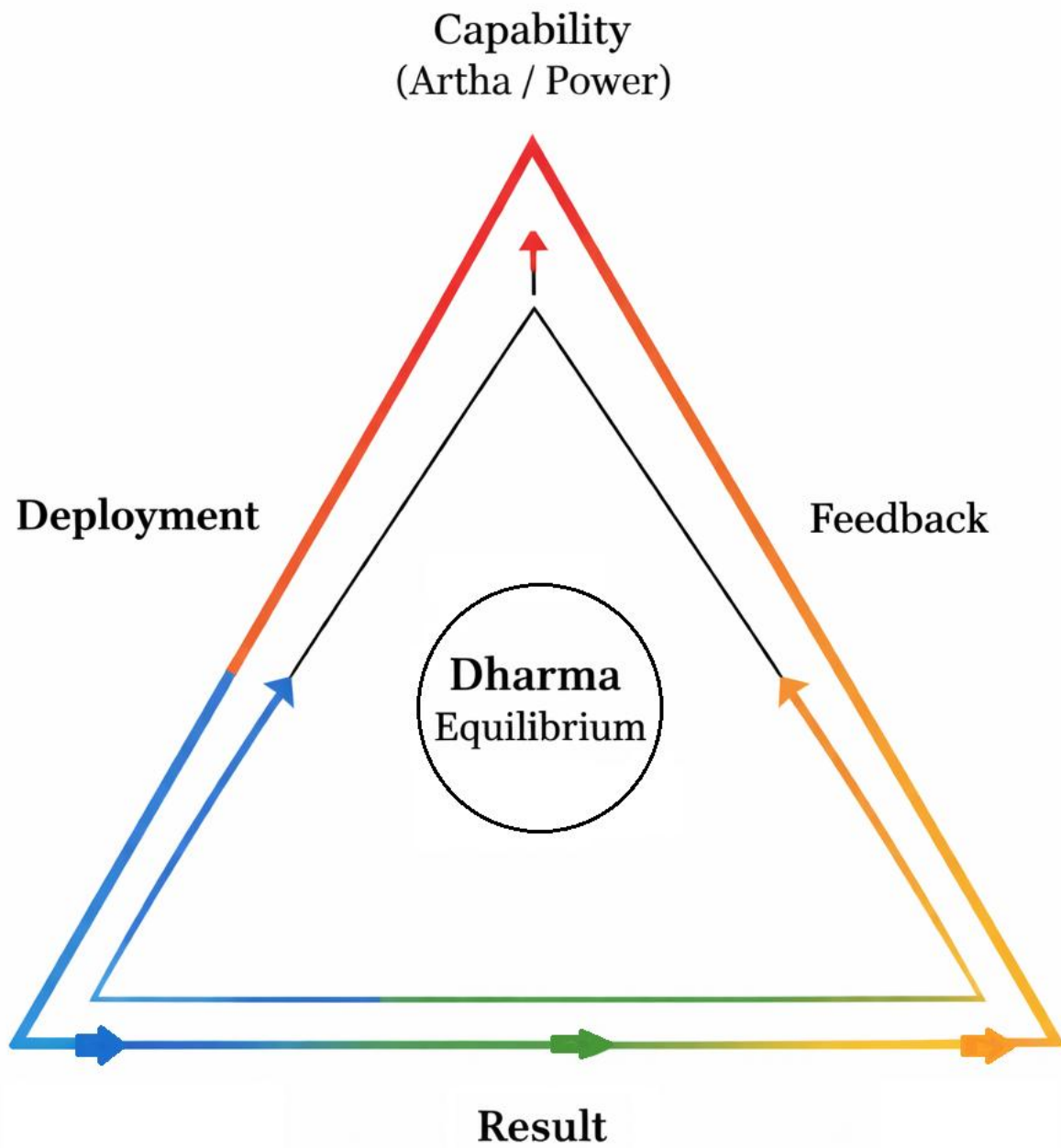


Figure 2. Dharma as systemic equilibrium: the dynamic alignment of capability, conduct, and consequence.

V. Policy Implications: Toward Dhārmic Stewardship

The adoption of a *dhārmic* framework shifts emphasis from rule-based compliance to consequence-oriented statecraft.

First, policies must be assessed not only for legality, but for their systemic effects. This includes evaluating large-scale satellite deployments, spectrum allocation, and emerging orbital infrastructure projects not only in terms of immediate utility, but in terms of their cumulative impact on congestion, stability, and long-term sustainability.

The increasing frequency of collision alerts and avoidance manoeuvres further underscores the need to evaluate space activity in systemic rather than purely operational terms.²³

This orientation must be informed by the accumulated experience of governance failures on Earth. Environmental degradation, regulatory lag, and the externalisation of systemic costs across domains such as climate and resource use illustrate the consequences of expansion unmoored from long-term equilibrium. The space domain presents an opportunity to internalise these lessons at an earlier stage, embedding principles of restraint, accountability, and systemic awareness before patterns of irreversible degradation emerge.

VI. Strategic Stressors: Militarisation and Resource Extraction

The sustainability of the cosmic commons is further challenged by trends toward militarisation, potential weaponisation, and the extraction of extraterrestrial resources. These developments introduce asymmetries in capability and incentives that may undermine systemic balance. Unrestrained militarisation risks escalation dynamics that destabilise the domain, while resource extraction without shared frameworks may generate exclusion and long-term inequity. These developments test the limits of ordering based on restraint, raising the

²³ Ibid.

question of whether systemic equilibrium can be sustained under conditions of intensified strategic competition.²⁴

Second, it reframes restraint as capability. This is particularly salient in a domain where commercial actors are rapidly expanding launch capacity and orbital presence, often outpacing the evolution of regulatory frameworks and shared norms of restraint.²⁵ In a fragile and interdependent domain, self-limitation becomes a condition of long-term power.

Third, it supports the development of flexible, issue-based coalitions, reflecting the dynamic relationships described in the *maṇḍala* framework.

Fourth, it highlights the importance of narrative and legitimacy in shaping norms and behaviour.

Finally, it provides a basis for reimagining space governance as an ongoing process of ordering, rather than a static system of rules.

VII. Conclusion: Ordering the Shared Future

The expansion of human activity into outer space represents not only a technological achievement, but a civilisational moment. The order that emerges in this domain will shape not only strategic outcomes, but the broader trajectory of human cooperation.

Such order cannot be sustained by power or institutions alone. It requires an integrating principle capable of aligning capability with consequence, and action with legitimacy. *Dharma*, understood as systemic equilibrium, provides such a principle.

To govern space is thus to undertake a deeper task: not merely to regulate activity, but to order a shared domain in which competition, cooperation, and meaning can coexist within a sustainable whole.

²⁴ Bledwyn E. Bowen, *War in Space: Strategy, Spacepower, Geopolitics* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2020); Namrata Goswami and Peter A. Garretson, *Scramble for the Skies: The Great Power Competition to Control the Resources of Outer Space* (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2020).

²⁵ McKee, “Bezos vs. Musk Space Race.”

The challenge is not only to extend human presence into space, but to ensure that such expansion is ordered in a manner that sustains both the domain and the civilisation that enters it.

The scale and consequence of human activity in outer space necessitate a longer temporal horizon than is typically employed in policy planning. A *dhārmic* approach to the cosmic commons invites the articulation of a multi-generational perspective, extending toward a century-scale view of human presence in space. Such a perspective does not seek to predict specific outcomes, but to ensure that expansion remains aligned with the conditions necessary for long-term stability, adaptability, and shared viability. The ordering of space, in this sense, is not a finite task but an ongoing civilisational commitment, one that will determine whether expansion deepens disorder or sustains a viable and enduring cosmic commons.

Appendix: Nāṭyaśāstra as a Manual for Embodied Transmission of Order in the Cosmic Commons

This appendix serves as a practical extension of the argument advanced in the main text. It is intended for practitioners within the Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam, offering a framework through which *nāṭya* may function as a mode of embodied transmission. Its purpose is not to prescribe themes, messages, or conclusions, but to cultivate a discipline through which action, expression, and experience may be aligned such that coherence, or *dharma*, becomes perceptible.²⁶ In this sense, it does not treat performance as communication in the narrow sense, but as the composition of a field of experience within which meaning may arise without being imposed.

The Structure of Experience

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* provides the underlying structure for this discipline. Its central insight is that experience emerges through the alignment of *bhāva*, *abhinaya*, and *rasa*.²⁷ *Bhāva* refers to the inner state or motivating condition; *abhinaya* to the means of expression through which that state becomes perceptible; and *rasa* to the realised experience that arises in the attuned spectator, the *sahṛdaya*. This sequence is not mechanical but relational. The practitioner does not transmit emotion directly, nor does the spectator passively receive it. Rather, the performance creates the conditions under which experience becomes intelligible and shareable. When stabilised through disciplined repetition, this alignment shapes expectations and dispositions, contributing to the internalisation of norms that cannot be secured through external enforcement alone. The task of the practitioner is therefore not to communicate a message, but to compose an experience in which meaning can emerge through alignment.

Discipline of the Practitioner

Within this framework, the role of the practitioner must be understood with precision. The practitioner is not a preacher, nor a narrator of conclusions, but a custodian of experiential coherence. This responsibility lies not in directing the

²⁶ Bharata Muni, *Nāṭyaśāstra*, trans. Manomohan Ghosh (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1951).

²⁷ Ibid.

audience toward a predetermined response, but in sustaining clarity of inner state and consistency of expression so that experience does not collapse into fragmentation. What is transmitted is not doctrine, but a condition of intelligibility. The distinction is critical: *nāṭya* operates not through assertion, but through evocation.

All performance begins with *bhāva*. In the present context, practitioners must recognise that contemporary experience is shaped by dominant experiential currents such as ambition, anxiety, urgency, and fragmentation. These are not to be reproduced uncritically, nor intensified for effect, but discerned in their underlying movement. The discipline lies in stabilising *bhāva*, holding it with clarity and proportion rather than allowing it to become excessive or diffused. When *bhāva* is unstable, expression becomes inconsistent, and no coherent experience can arise. Discernment thus precedes expression; without it, technique becomes superficial.

This discipline may be further understood as a progression through *sādhana* (sustained practice), *dhyāna* (attentional refinement), *tapasyā* (endurance and self-regulation), and *yātrā* (an ongoing journey of alignment). These are not discrete stages but interrelated modes through which coherence is cultivated and stabilised over time. Together, these cultivate continuity between inner discipline and outward expression.

Abhinaya, as the mode of expression, renders *bhāva* perceptible. It encompasses gesture, movement, rhythm, spatial arrangement, and narrative sequencing. Its discipline lies in alignment. Expression must remain consistent with the inner state it seeks to embody, neither exaggerating nor diluting it. Economy of movement becomes essential, not as minimalism, but as precision. Each gesture must be necessary, each transition intelligible. Just as inconsistency between intent and action undermines legitimacy in public life, disjunction between *bhāva* and *abhinaya* produces aesthetic dissonance. The practitioner's task is therefore to ensure that expression forms a coherent extension of inner state, so that the performance may be apprehended as a unified act rather than a series of disconnected elements.

Rasa arises not through direct production, but through the sustained alignment of *bhāva* and *abhinaya*. The practitioner does not attempt to control the response of the audience. Instead, the performance creates conditions in which the spectator, as *sahr̥daya*, becomes capable of attuned perception. This requires restraint as much as intensity. Excessive emphasis, forced emotionality, or premature resolution disrupt the process by which experience matures. Classical aesthetic theory clarifies that *rasa* is not the raw experience of emotion, but its transformation into a form that is contemplative and shareable.²⁸ The practitioner therefore allows experience to unfold, maintaining rhythm and proportion so that insight may arise without coercion.

This orientation must be carefully distinguished from didactic performance. The practitioner does not illustrate moral propositions, direct the audience toward fixed conclusions, or reduce performance to message. Instead, experience is structured rather than imposed, and meaning is evoked rather than declared. The spectator is not instructed but enabled. In this lies the difference between transmission and persuasion. Where persuasion seeks to influence, transmission sustains a field within which recognition becomes possible.

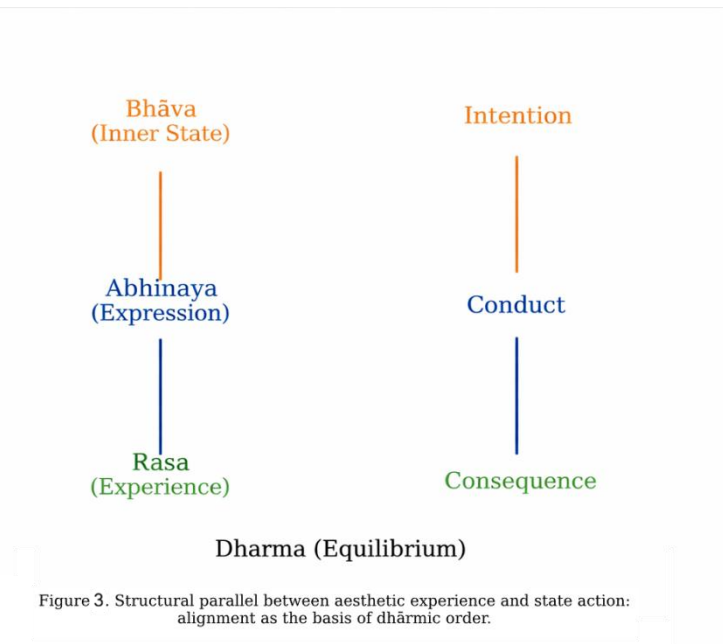
The discipline of practice also requires attention to calibration. Contemporary environments tend toward intensification across spectacle, speed, and emotional excess. The practitioner's role is not to replicate this intensification, but to restore proportion. This involves modulating tempo, regulating emphasis, and allowing space within the performance for resolution and reflection. Calibration does not diminish energy; it orders it. Through this ordering, the performance avoids both agitation and stagnation, sustaining instead a dynamic equilibrium.

Coherence across the performance as a whole is equally essential. A sequence of technically proficient segments does not necessarily produce a unified experience. The practitioner must ensure continuity, integrity of transitions, and consistency of internal logic. Each segment must relate to the whole, contributing to an overall field of experience that can be apprehended as coherent. When such

²⁸ Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, in Gnoli, *The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta* (Rome: Istituto Italiano per il Medio ed Estremo Oriente, 1956).

coherence is sustained, the performance becomes not a collection of parts, but a single, intelligible movement.

When *bhāva*, *abhinaya*, and *rasa* are thus aligned, a condition of equilibrium becomes perceptible. This may be understood as the experiential manifestation of *dharma*. It is not announced or imposed, but recognised. Such recognition does not eliminate complexity or tension; rather, it allows them to be held within a coherent frame. In this sense, *dharma* is not conveyed as doctrine, but realised as experience. In this way, the alignment of *bhāva*, *abhinaya*, and *rasa* finds a direct analogue in the alignment of intent, conduct, and consequence in state action, linking experiential coherence to systemic stability. This parallel highlights how internal consistency at the level of intention translates into stability at the level of outcomes.



Within the Nāṭyaśāstra Gurukulam, this framework situates *nāṭya* as a mode of civilisational practice. The aim extends beyond performance as display or technique. It involves the cultivation of the capacity to hold and transmit complex states of experience in a manner that is ordered, proportionate, and sustaining. The practitioner becomes, in this sense, a custodian of experiential order, participating in the broader task articulated in the main text: the alignment of action, perception, and principle within a shared domain.

In a world marked by fragmentation and acceleration, such practice assumes particular significance. It offers a means not of simplifying experience, but of rendering it coherent and inhabitable. The practitioner does not communicate doctrine, but composes experience. Through this composition, order becomes perceptible without being imposed, and the possibility of equilibrium emerges within the very act of performance, with implications that extend to the ordering of shared domains through the alignment of action, perception, and principle.

From Embodied Practice to Civilisational Order

The relevance of this discipline to the ordering of the cosmic commons lies in its capacity to cultivate an internalised orientation toward consequence. In domains such as outer space, where enforcement mechanisms remain limited and visibility is high, stability depends on the ability of actors to anticipate systemic effects and regulate their conduct accordingly. The practice of *nāṭya* develops this capacity by training attention to alignment across intention, expression, and outcome. It sensitises the practitioner to excess, dissonance, and fragmentation, not as abstract risks but as perceptible conditions. This cultivated sensibility is transferable. It shapes how action is composed beyond performance, informing judgment in contexts where formal rules are insufficient. In this sense, embodied practice functions as a preparatory ground for *dhārmic* statecraft, enabling forms of action that sustain, rather than degrade, the shared domain.
